
DESIGN RESEARCH DOSSIER

Business Navigator

Personal-brand website — visual research

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Scope: PERSONAL websites only — coaches, mentors, authors, speakers, and individual portfolios. Corporate / SaaS excluded (a personal brand has the design freedom they don't). 16 sites analysed before this build; data extracted live from each site's DOM. Screenshots: Chrome CDP capture errored, so this dossier uses extracted fonts/palettes + written visual breakdowns (noted honestly).

Contents

- 1 — Synthesis: what makes a personal mentor site beautiful
- 2 — Three style directions (with palettes)
- 3 — Site-by-site analysis (16 personal/coach sites)

What makes a personal mentor site beautiful

- Warm neutrals, never pure #000/#fff. Emil Kowalski, James Clear, Marie Forleo all use warm off-white (#faf6ef) + warm ink (#15110c). Pure black/white reads "corporate/clinical."
- The PORTRAIT is the hero. Marie Forleo, Lewis Howes, Ali Abdaal, Sahil Bloom, Dan Martell all lead with a big, confident photo of the person. On a personal site the face sells.
- Editorial serif = authority + warmth. Marie (IvyPresto), James Clear (Minion), Justin Welsh (Playfair). A serif keeps a *sales* topic from feeling like fintech/SaaS.
- Headline/name at heroic scale. Snellenberg (name @252px), Sahil Bloom (@151px). Confidence through size.
- ONE surprising accent (Marie's lime, Lewis's orange) or a refined gold (James Clear). Not a rainbow.
- Personality through ONE distinctive type choice — Recoleta (friendly), Bebas (sales energy), Eksell (quirky character).
- Script accent on a single word humanizes a bold headline (Lewis Howes).
- Generous editorial spacing, storytelling scroll, big readable type. No thin/illegible display fonts.

Directions for the redesign

Style A — "EDITORIAL AUTHORITY"



Vibe: premium, calm, "the person who wrote the book on sales systems."

Mode: warm near-black. Fonts: Playfair Display (readable elegant serif) + Inter.

Palette: #100D0A warm ink bg · #F4ECDD cream · #E3B45F gold accent · #A9A08C muted.

Hero: huge serif headline + large confident portrait, gold accent on one word, editorial spacing.

Signature: big editorial portrait + a single gold thread; quiet prestige.

Style B — "SALES MOMENTUM"



Vibe: bold, high-energy, momentum — for an ambitious sales operator.

Mode: off-white bright + black. Fonts: Anton (condensed caps display) + Inter.

Palette: #F5F1EA warm white · #16130F ink · #FF5A1F electric orange accent · #1E63FF secondary.

Hero: oversized condensed all-caps headline, big portrait, orange CTA energy, kinetic numbers.

Signature: condensed caps = sales drive; one electric accent keeps it modern, not infomercial.

Style C — "WARM HUMAN"



Vibe: approachable, human, smart-but-not-intimidating.

Mode: warm cream light. Fonts: Newsreader (friendly readable serif) + Inter/Mulish.

Palette: #F7F0E6 cream · #F0E2CF peach panel · #1B1610 ink · #C9703E terracotta · #3F9C8E teal pop.

Hero: big warm portrait + friendly serif headline, rounded cards, 2 cheerful accents, storytelling scroll.

Signature: rounded warmth + soft secondary palette = "this mentor is human and on your side."

16 personal / coach-mentor sites

1. Justin Welsh — justinwelsh.me [personal / solopreneur mentor]



FONTS

Display: Playfair Display / Body: Lora

HERO PATTERN

Warm near-black background, large 56px serif headline in cream, single-column editorial, very restrained.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Serif-on-serif (Playfair + Lora) on a warm black (not cold #000) — reads like a personal letterpress book, intimate and authored.

TAKEAWAY

Warm near-black + cream + serif = instant "trusted personal mentor." A direct reference for Business Navigator's most premium direction.

2. Dennis Snellenberg — dennissnellenberg.com [personal / designer portfolio, Awwwards SOTY]



FONTS

Display/Body: Dennis Sans (bespoke grotesk), weight 450

HERO PATTERN

His NAME set at a colossal 252px filling the viewport, charcoal canvas, a single blue link accent, cursor-following circular hover labels.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Name-as-hero at extreme scale + a custom-named typeface ("Dennis Sans") — the personality IS the type. Smooth Locomotive scroll, magnetic buttons, page transitions.

TAKEAWAY

A personal site can lead with the person's NAME at heroic scale. One accent color, charcoal ground, a custom-feeling sans = confident and unmistakably his.

3. Robin Noguier — robin-noguier.com [personal / interactive designer portfolio]



FONTS

Display: Eksell Display (characterful serif) / Body: Silka

HERO PATTERN

Near-black canvas, expressive 157px display serif, full-screen project imagery that reveals on scroll with WebGL hover.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

A quirky display serif (Eksell, with playful ball terminals) paired with a clean grotesk body — personality from the typeface choice, not decoration. Muted teal as the only color.

TAKEAWAY

One distinctive display serif gives a personal site instant character. Pair it with a neutral grotesk so it stays legible and adult.

4. Brittany Chiang — brittanychiang.com [personal / engineer portfolio]



FONTS

Display/Body: Inter (700 for name)

HERO PATTERN

Two-column — left half is a STICKY intro (name, role, nav) that stays fixed; right half scrolls through work. 48px name.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

The sticky split layout: identity pinned left, content streaming right. Slate-navy + single teal accent + spotlight cursor glow.

TAKEAWAY

A sticky-left identity panel keeps the person present the whole scroll — ideal for a mentor whose face/credibility should

never leave the screen.

5. Aristide Benoist — aristidebenoist.com [personal / independent developer portfolio]



FONTS

Display: JWS + TNY (custom) · Times accent

HERO PATTERN

Cinematic WebGL transitions between full-bleed project worlds, each with its own color world emerging from a dark base.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Per-section color "worlds" (sage, gold, cream, pink) blooming out of near-black — color used as narrative chapters, fluid shader transitions.

TAKEAWAY

A personal site can shift palette per section to tell a story (origin → method → results). Anchor on dark, let each chapter own a warm hue.

6. Rauno Freiberg — rauno.me [personal / interaction designer]



FONTS

Display/Body: custom minimal sans (X) · Times accent

HERO PATTERN

A single quiet sentence intro at modest 32px on light grey — almost a document, with exquisitely crafted micro-interactions.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Extreme restraint + obsessive micro-detail (custom focus rings, springy toggles, pixel-perfect spacing). The polish IS the personality.

TAKEAWAY

Less can read as more expensive IF every micro-interaction is flawless. For a mentor, this says "I sweat the details."

7. Paco Coursey — paco.me [personal / engineer-designer]



FONTS

Display: Söhne / Body: Inter · Newsreader (serif accent)

HERO PATTERN

A quiet single-column "now/writing" index on dark, modest type, lots of breathing room.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Söhne (Swiss grotesk) for UI + Newsreader serif for prose — a sans/serif voice split that signals "designer who also writes." Subtle command-menu polish.

TAKEAWAY

Mix a Swiss grotesk (authority) with a literary serif (Newsreader) for long-form. Useful for a mentor who publishes essays/lessons.

8. Emil Kowalski — emilkowal.ski [personal / designer-educator, "Animations on the Web"]



FONTS

Display/Body: refined sans · Times accent

HERO PATTERN

Bright, warm-white reading surface, generous line-height, course/essay index — feels like a beautifully set book page.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

An entirely warm greyscale (off-white → warm ink, no pure #fff/#000) that makes a light theme feel soft and human, not clinical.

TAKEAWAY

For a LIGHT direction, shift every neutral warm (#fdfdfc / #21201c). Warm light = approachable mentor, not sterile SaaS.

9. Bruno Simon — bruno-simon.com [personal / creative developer portfolio]



Fonts

Display: Amatic SC (hand-drawn) + Pally / Body: Nunito

Hero Pattern

A fully drivable 3D toy-car world — you steer a car around his projects. Pure WebGL playground.

Visual Signature

Turns the portfolio into a game; soft hand-drawn display font (Amatic) signals warmth/play against a techy 3D scene.

Takeaway

Probably too playful for a sales mentor, but the lesson holds: ONE memorable interactive idea makes a site unforgettable. (Use a restrained version.)

10. Marie Forleo — marieforleo.com [★ coach-mentor / NYT author, B-School — direct analog]



Fonts

Display: IvyPresto Display (high-contrast serif) / Body: Area Normal (geometric sans)

Hero Pattern

Huge 120px elegant serif headline over a confident founder portrait, warm cream ground, generous editorial spacing.

Visual Signature

High-contrast display serif (IvyPresto) for warmth + authority, big founder photography, a warm-neutral palette with ONE unexpected pop (lime). Premium-feminine but ungendered enough to adapt.

Takeaway

This is the template-killer reference for Business Navigator: editorial serif + warm cream + big personal portrait + a single surprising accent. Steal the structure.

11. Lewis Howes — lewishowes.com [coach-mentor / podcaster, author]



Fonts

Display: Museo Sans (700) + script accent Bethany Elingston / Body: Museo Sans

Hero Pattern

124px bold sans headline ("Become the Hero...") + big confident portrait, warm-white ground, orange CTA energy.

Visual Signature

A hand-script accent word dropped into a bold-sans headline adds human warmth; single high-energy orange drives all CTAs.

Takeaway

A script accent on one word humanizes a bold headline. One energetic accent color = motivational without being loud everywhere.

12. Ali Abdaal — aliabdaal.com [coach-mentor / productivity, author]



Fonts

Display: Recoleta (friendly rounded serif) / Body: Elza (warm grotesk)

Hero Pattern

Big friendly portrait + Recoleta headline on warm cream, cheerful multi-accent palette, rounded cards.

Visual Signature

Recoleta's soft rounded serifs + a playful but controlled secondary palette (sky/yellow) = "approachable expert" — smart but never intimidating.

Takeaway

Recoleta is the friendliest credible serif. Pair with warm cream + 2 cheerful accents for a "this mentor is human and fun" read.

13. Sahil Bloom — sahilbloom.com [coach-mentor / writer, investor]



FONTS

Display: Bely Display (elegant serif) / Body: Brooklyn sans

HERO PATTERN

His NAME in 151px Bely serif, navy ground, big portrait, blue accent — authority-forward.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Name-as-hero in a refined serif over deep navy — "established author" gravity. The serif keeps the blue from feeling corporate.

TAKEAWAY

If the brand needs blue/navy authority, anchor it with a literary serif name-hero so it reads "thought leader," not "fintech."

14. Tim Ferriss — tim.blog [coach-mentor / author, podcaster]



FONTS

Display/Body: DM Sans · Times accent

HERO PATTERN

Content-first editorial blog, warm-white reading column, restrained blue links — built for trust and reading volume.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Almost anti-design restraint — the credibility of the writing is the brand; warm whites keep a text-heavy site inviting.

TAKEAWAY

For a mentor who teaches via long content, a warm-white reading-first layout signals substance over hype.

15. James Clear — jamesclear.com [coach-mentor / Atomic Habits author]



FONTS

Display: Minion Pro (classic book serif) / Body: Europa (humanist sans)

HERO PATTERN

A book-like cream page, classic serif headings, single-column reading, gold accent on key CTAs.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Minion Pro (the typeface of literary books) instantly signals "author/teacher." Cream + gold = quiet prestige, zero hype.

TAKEAWAY

A traditional book serif (Minion/Source Serif) + cream + gold = "this person wrote the book on it." Powerful for a sales authority.

16. Dan Martell — danmartell.com [coach-mentor / coach for founders, author "Buy Back Your Time"]



FONTS

Display: Bebas Neue (condensed caps) / Body: Poppins

HERO PATTERN

75px condensed all-caps headline on black, big portrait, cyan accent CTAs — punchy, high-energy.

VISUAL SIGNATURE

Bebas Neue condensed caps = sales-energy/urgency; black + one electric cyan keeps it modern, not infomercial.

TAKEAWAY

A condensed display face delivers "sales momentum." For Business Navigator's bold direction, condensed caps + black + one electric accent could fit a sales mentor well — but use sparingly so it stays premium.
